stake. Patil is working on all fronts to ensure success, even willing to deviate from his earlier stand that nobody from the Congress would be inducted in the BJP. Among those he won over from the Congress is Jayraj Singh Parmar, a former spokesperson for the party, who joined the BJP in February and can influence 4-5 assembly constituencies in Mehsana district of north Gujarat. Many more defectors are likely to be welcomed.

Apart from these moves, Patil is relying on the BJP's strong organisational network to beat anti-incumbency. Pradeepsinh Vaghela, the 41-year-old BJP general secretary, keeps tabs on the support base, sitting in the party headquarters in Gandhinagar. He says the '*panna pramukh* (page committee)' system has been a robust mechanism to consolidate supporters. Each page of the voters' list has 30 names, and a committee of five party workers is supposed to monitor them. "We have a target of appointing 71 lakh page committee members. At present, we have 62 lakh," says Vaghela, a firebrand next generation leader. "We will have 35 lakh active workers encouraging voters to vote for BJP." The party has also made a list of '*kriyasheel karyakarta* (active workers)'—those who have added at least 100 new members—and given them smart ID cards so that the leaders can be immediately updated when they add more members.

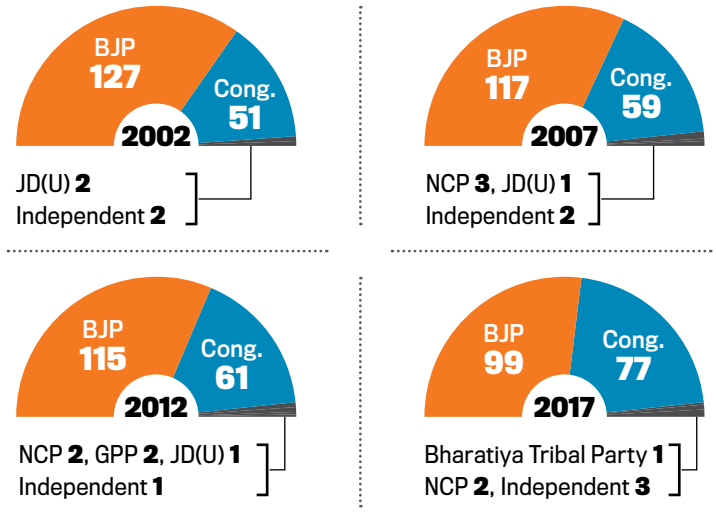
Caste dynamics also favour the BJP. While the prime minister remains its biggest magnet for all communities, the party also has a battery of leaders from both sections of the Patidar community—Kadva Patels and Leuva Patels. While CM Bhupendra Patel is a Kadva Patel, Union health minister Mansukh Mandaviya is a Leuva Patel. The party also has a sizeable presence among the OBCs (other backward classes)—Kolis and Thakors—while upper-caste Hindus have been loyal BJP voters for more than three decades.

To dodge anti-incumbency, the BJP had replaced the entire cabinet under Vijay Rupani with new ministers led by Bhupendra Patel in September 2021. Now, the government is looking to win over voters with a thrust on the Mukhyamantri Amrutum Yojana, its mass health insurance scheme, and by providing tapped water to every household. It expects to achieve the target of 100 per cent tapped water supply by September. "We have completed 93 per cent work. The rest will be done soon," says a senior official from the CM's office.

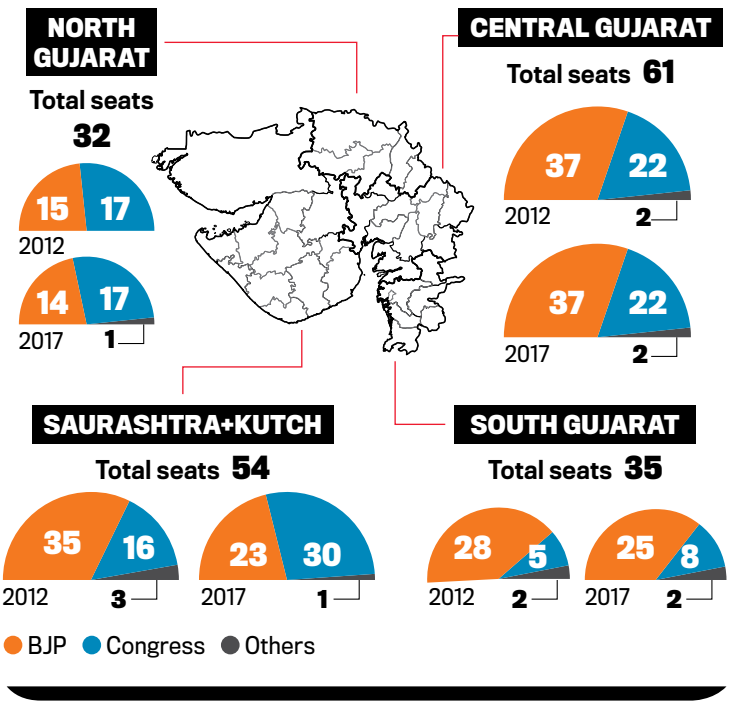
However, the CM's low public profile and rising inflation may hamper the BJP's prospects. "Even after eight months, many people do not know who the CM is," says a senior BJP leader. "Humble and modest, he likes to stay away from the public glare, but the time has come to be vocal."

Meanwhile, rising prices of fuel, gas and electricity have shaken the middle class, the BJP's core voter base. Ahmedabad resident Mitul Patel complains that his electricity bill for two months was a whopping Rs 18,000. "I use two air conditioners in my house, but this power bill is unprecedented," he says. The prices of piped gas and CNG, too, have gone up. "Commut-

ASSEMBLY PERFORMANCE



REGIONWISE BREAK-UP



Graphics by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**